

Corrosion

Oxygen is highly reactive and forms compounds known as oxides with other elements. Similar to combustion but much slower, corrosion is a reaction in which oxygen in the air reacts with metals to create oxides. The most common form of corrosion is rust, which forms when iron reacts with oxygen and water.



Pile of
rusted screws



Chalcopyrite, a sulfide ore
of copper and iron

Ores

Natural substances containing useful materials, such as metals, are known as ores. Many important ores are compounds with members of the oxygen group, most often oxygen and sulfur.

Pure elements

Some members of this group are found pure in nature. While oxygen makes up one-fifth of the air, solid sulfur is found in volcanic areas, where the naturally hot conditions allow pure sulfur to separate from its compounds.

Deposits of pure sulfur in the
Danakil Depression, Ethiopia

